> …within this last century, a great many Persians, and even entire Families, have gone and settl'd in the Indies. As they are a handsomer, wiser and more polite People, beyond all comparison, than the Mahometan Indians, who are descended from the Tartars, in the Country of Tamerlane…[they] go willingly where Fortune invites them, especially into a Country, which is one of the most plentiful of the World.

A poem written as a caustic challenge to Shah Abbas of Persia demonstrated the great lure of Hindustan, which was now being called the Dar al-Aman, the abode of peace:

> That in Persia no one comes within sight,
> Who is a customer of the commodity of meaning;
> In Persia the palate of my soul has become bitter,
> Go I ought towards Hindustan;
> Like a drop towards the ocean,
> I may send my commodity to India.

The visitors to the court may have appreciated playing cards, a game popular throughout the Mughal Empire, and with Akbar and his men, for the Padshah had made suitable alterations to the suit of cards to satisfactorily reflect this new reality of Hindustan. Now each of the twelve kings was distinct and represented a particular strength or region. So Akbar played with the suit representing the King of Delhi, shown with the insignia of royalty such as the umbrella, standard etc. Then there was the King of Elephants, representing the ruler of Orissa. There was the King of Infantry, with a nod to the rulers of Bijapur, a King of Forts, Dhanpati, the King of Wealth, a King of the Fleet, and even a suit called Tipati, in which the ruler was a Queen. The most lowly was the Padshah-e-Ghulam, whose suit consisted of servants 'some of whom sit, some lie on the ground in worship, some are drunk, others sober etc.'

Besides playing cards, another form of entertainment that grew in popularity was the habit of reading. In Fatehpur Sikri, booksellers hunkered down by the roadside, beside piles of diwans of Persian immigrant poets. The most popular of these poets was Urfi Shirazi, a young poet with a sharply acerbic wit. Shirazi and the poet laureate of Akbar's court, Faizi, had a brittle disregard for each other, testing each other on the jagged edge of their poetry. Faizi had once taken on the orthographically challenging